

Isn't it majorly hypocritical to be against AI for the impact on the environment??

Posted by u/NYANPUG55 • 0 points • 10 comments

To preface, I do not like ai art and writing because it feeds on other people's works and discourages human creativity. I feel it's stealing as people's whose works it takes are not compensated. But I see a lot of people saying it's horrible for the environment, but isn't pretty much every other unnecessary apps people use? Like Instagram, Reddit, Streaming apps, etc?

Comments

u/Worried-Language-407 • 2 points • 2025-08-04 02:21 UTC

Neural networks, which are the back-end of generative AI, are very intensive on particular kinds of maths, which means most of the big AI companies run them from enormous server banks which are absolutely loaded with specialised chips which are similar to graphics cards (and in some cases actually are graphics cards bought in bulk).

Obviously every app and website is run from enormous servers, but the systems used for generative AI are especially energy intensive. They require lots of energy just to power the computers, and then they also need a huge amount of energy to keep things cool in the server room, and in some places they are a significant drain on the local water supply as well, to use for coolant. Basically, they are using crazy amounts of electricity, much more so than other apps and websites.

An additional factor is that the chips that they use require quite high amounts of some rare metals, and the extraction of these metals is bad for the environment. Again, normal computers would make use of these metals to some extent, and the pollution which comes from their mining would still happen, but thanks to AI companies the demand is much higher which means more mining and more pollution.

u/NYANPUG55 • 1 points • 2025-08-04 02:25 UTC

Thank you so much for this explanation! That makes a lot more sense. Is this just this basics of how ai generation works or is it a matter of finding a more energy efficient way to run these programs?

u/hellshot8 • 2 points • 2025-08-04 02:19 UTC

the issue is the scale

u/NYANPUG55 • 2 points • 2025-08-04 02:21 UTC

Can you expand on that? Like the amount of people using it? Or that even though not everyone uses it, it takes much more to run it at a minimum than it does other things?

u/Timely-Cupcake5621 • 1 points • 2025-08-04 02:34 UTC

Because the technology is much more advanced, it requires much bigger computers, which in turn require enormous amounts of fresh water to be kept cool.

u/hellshot8 • 2 points • 2025-08-04 02:23 UTC

the scale of energy it uses per query is unbelievable. Someone using an app uses almost no electricity, whereas AI uses huge amounts

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 1 points • 2025-08-04 02:32 UTC

> the scale of energy it uses per query is unbelievable.

Can you back up that claim with some source? OpenAI isnt really open about their resource usage, but you can run stable diffusion on any 800W gaming PC to generate HD pictures in 2minutes, thatd not "unbelievable" by any means.

DeepSeek and LLama3 run on your local phone hardware in real time.

So i really dont believe your claim is true at all.

u/hellshot8 • 1 points • 2025-08-04 02:35 UTC

<https://www.technologyreview.com/2025/05/20/1116327/ai-energy-usage-climate-footprint-big-tech/>

<https://www.iea.org/news/ai-is-set-to-drive-surging-electricity-demand-from-data-centres-while-offering-the-potential-to-transform-how-the-energy-sector-works>

<https://iee.psu.edu/news/blog/why-ai-uses-so-much-energy-and-what-we-can-do-about-it>

<https://e360.yale.edu/features/artificial-intelligence-climate-energy-emissions>

<https://www.npr.org/2024/07/10/nx-s1-5028558/artificial-intelligences-thirst-for-electricity>

<https://www.nytimes.com/2024/07/11/climate/artificial-intelligence-energy-usage.html>

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 2 points • 2025-08-04 04:36 UTC

Well i have gone through the first link and it agrees with my estimates, so whats your point.

The article first mentions a lot about how much energy the whole industry of AI uses, and that sounds like a lot until you compare it with other big datacenters like what google uses for its search or netflix and youtube use up.

The actual per response power usage is in the 1000 to 6000 jules.

<https://www.gigacalculator.com/converters/convert-joules-to-watts.php>

If you convert that to Watts with this <https://www.gigacalculator.com/converters/convert-joules-to-watts.php>

joules-to-watts.php

And assume it takes a minute you get to something like 20 to 100watts

My gaming PC has an 800W power supply to set that in context.

So my conclusion up until now is still: an AI uses even with the highest possible estimate about as much energy as a microwave oven! Thats absolutley not an inreasonable amount of electricity!

I will read through the other articles when i have time, but i realy doubt they will land at any estimates thats like 100 or more times that, and thats what i would call a lot even of its still not comparable to most industrial scale production processes.

u/archpawn • 1 points • 2025-08-04 02:18 UTC

I think a lot of people are under the impression that it's more harmful than it is. And you could in theory be vehemently against anything else that uses just as much electricity, though you probably wouldn't spend a whole lot of time on Reddit since it doesn't take all that long to use the same amount of electricity to run your computer.

u/Scared_Research_8426 • 2 points • 2025-08-04 02:17 UTC

The scale at which ai uses resources is much, much greater.

Much